

What Is Religion?

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RELS271: What is Religion?

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What is religion? I entered this semester with vague notions about the term's meaning, not having given it much deeper thought. I learned about a few of the major "world religions" in required social studies classes before college, and once turned to Buddhism during quarantine in search of a solution for my overwhelming teenage angst. Most of my generalizations on religion however, were tied back to my limited encounters with Christianity. I remember reading Sergio Cariello's *The Picture Bible* in first grade; admiring the action, the attention to detail and bold colors in every illustration. My family was never religious – the fact that we possessed a picture bible was probably a larger reflection of Christian influences in American culture and my family's weak attempt to assimilate. In dire situations – mixed signals from a crush, for example – I'd sometimes lie in my bed and pray to God; to the imagination of an old, wise, silver-bearded Caucasian man peering down on me from the sky. But enough about my scattered religious background, let's return our focus to the prompt.

Due to the immense diversity of religions that exist or have existed across the globe, combined with the many – often conflicting – perceptions of religion by scholars throughout time, it's rather difficult to come up with a singular cohesive definition that successfully encompasses all religions. However, for the sake of this assignment I will attempt to do so. I would like to characterize religion as a universal phenomenon with five primary components: The first component, the belief in some form of Sacredness, is often the main marker many scholars use in differentiating religious activity from profane activity. Mircea Eliade would argue that religion originates from the sacred; not only is sacred experience "real" or human, but the Sacred itself is real and universal, as human nature innately compels us to seek and access it; the core of religion is the Sacred (2025.02.10, 17-18). Second, the potential for and existence of individual religious consciousness, allows us to inspect religion as a phenomenon that occurs within individuals' own consciousness and alters it, imbuing it with a "profound sustaining knowledge" (2025.01.27, 2). William James' works on religious mysticism focuses on personal religious experience, claiming that the latter is rooted in mystical states of consciousness (James, 318). Psychological research on religion views one's mind as "the locus of religion"(Soliman et al, 852), and suggests that people interpret God's actions and shape their understanding of the supernatural/divine–*the Sacred*–via their

sensorimotor capacities and own bodily experiences (Soliman et al, 854). Third, ritual/forms of reverential activity, are typically how religions physically and culturally express their beliefs, principles, and practices. Historian Jonathan Z. Smith reiterates missionary Joseph de Costa's description of religion as "the belief system that results in ceremonial behavior"(Smith, 270). Most of the world's art, architecture, traditional music and dance, cultural norms, and the U.S's holidays are popularized and institutionalized performances of religious ritual. Fourth, religion acts as a guide for morality and social order. The case for this is widespread, as we can observe how religion has historically and continues to shape not only individual behavior and ethics, but the laws and functioning of society. David Brooks, a Jewish-Christian Canadian-American writer, argues that the first movement of faith or religion is "the desire to become a better version of yourself" and the second is "the movement to heal the world"(Brooks, 8). Soliman and his team found through their experiments that a religion's followers' "synchronous activities... perform the same function in fostering group cohesion"(Soliman et al, 860). The fifth and final component, an organized structure centered around a specific doctrine(s), frames religion as a system that operates on a set of tenets followers are largely expected to adhere to, thus creating the structures people use to learn about and categorize different religions. Religious doctrines are often officialized via scriptures and promulgated through formal written or oral traditions. Religions can flood one's life with meaning and direction via *a religious worldview* that elucidates "what exists, what can be known, what should be valued, how one should behave, and what the immediate and ultimate goals of life ought to be" (Soliman, 859). Not every religion must share all these components equally or even possess all five elements, and while many religions share similarities in their possession of certain components, their interpretations, beliefs, and practices diverge; there is no singular component that determines whether something is or is not a religion. For convenience, most religions should meet at least a few of the criteria listed above, as leaving the definition too loose might blur the lines between religion and something else. Therefore, I'd identify my definition as a family-resemblance approach. The four religions I will be focusing on the most in this essay are Buddhism, Hinduism, and Islam.

Buddhism would qualify as a religion in accordance with my definition. To begin with, it assumes an ultimate truth alongside a higher reality based on the Buddha's dharma (Deming, 111), the ultimate goal of earthly existence being reunion with *the divine* (2025.03.31, 2). The Buddha is held sacred among his followers as his teachings on suffering, on nirvana/enlightenment, and his recorded life are revered and form the basis of all practice. Soliman states that "at the core of many religions, ideation is the belief in a parallel reality inhabited by immaterial agents; the possibility of transcending the physical body both during and after this life; and a belief in the causes, effects, and forces outside the physical world"(Soliman et al, 852). I'd consider that such transcendence and ideation of some other "immaterial" world beyond the physical, scientific plane of existence constitutes a belief in a form of Sacredness, a higher power, space, or universe that isn't inherently tangible for ordinary beings; the unifying aim of Buddhism being enlightenment, reaching a level of being on par with the Buddha, is precisely that. The steps for accomplishing this are laid out and founded in the Four Noble Truths, the Eightfold Path, and the Three Jewels (the Buddha, the Sangha, the Dharma) (Deming, 73), which have largely been learned through the Pali Canon and Abhidharma. These tenets and the scriptures they're found in are central to the organization and structure of Buddhism and its practices, and can be labeled as religious doctrines since they propagate a religious worldview aligned with the Buddha. Arisen from these teachings are certain "moral rules," *sila*, and the more well-known concept of *karma*, as many Buddhists believe that "morality is the gateway to truth and wisdom"(Deming, 98); a major example of Buddhism directing its followers' ethics and behavior. There's also the more recent development of "engaged Buddhism"(92), which author Will Deming describes as Buddhism's shift toward social activism. Aside from the philosophical takeaways of Buddhist teachings in texts on attaining nirvana, one typically must perform certain rituals as well, one of the most essential practices on the path to Bodhisattva being meditation. Furthermore, in Buddhist societies/countries, a major part of their culture involves veneration of the Buddha as expressed through holy ceremonies, *puja*, festivals, and coordinated temple visits (Deming, 103); fulfills the ritual/reverential activity component of my definition. Lastly, Buddhism by nature is grounded in individual religious consciousness, as its methods to enlightenment innately influence

personal meditative and scholarly practices, reflection, and one's inner relationship with the *Divine* and perception of the ultimate reality. Part of the Noble Eightfold Path in right contemplation, *samadhi*, where one seeks to cultivate "a sense of blissful *inner* peace"(2025.03.31, 9).

Next we'll discuss Hinduism, and though it's often described as a "way of life" rather than a "religion"(Narayanan, 337), I'd still fit it into my definition of religion. Because Hinduism encompasses such a diverse amount of cultural practices, philosophies, and traditions, it's difficult to identify any singular substantial structural core, organization, or doctrine, especially when the term itself "started life as basically a cultural expression, referring to *the way or ways of life* of a culturally unified and geographically designated people"(Lipner, 5). Lipner implies that the term's abstraction, the -ism attached to it, plays a role in perpetuating incorrect assumptions of there being one standard form of Hinduism. He suggests a polycentric, "banyan tree" model of Hinduism and uses the examples of the Vedas' transient authority (it "can drop out of or enter the system by force of historical circumstance without impairing ... the modality of the whole") and the "vast array of different sects, cults, and denominations, each with its own stem system of worship and belief"(Lipner, 11) to showcase it. Polycentric religions have no "unified set of beliefs" or "unified doctrine," and the "adoption of Hindu concepts and terms into multiple languages" demonstrates that Hinduism is not tied "to a singular doctrine"(2025.03.24, 4). Nonetheless, Hinduism's lack of one definitive doctrine, organization, or structure does not indicate failure to meet my definition's fifth component; rather I'd argue alongside Lipner that Hinduism as a whole can be thought of like a banyan, composed of *many* doctrines and sub-structures; the overarching doctrine, organization, and structure *is itself* the acknowledgement and composition of many doctrines and structures, hence the adjective "polycentric." Within the different sects and systems of practice and belief reveal Hindus' recognition of some type of Sacred, performances of ritual/ceremonial activity, individual religious experiences, and the moral and social guidelines shaping their communities. *Shruti*, "the sacred word," is revealed visually and audibly through cultural practices and "is characteristic of *all* Hindu traditions"(Narayanan, 303): despite the extraordinary diversity of Hindu systems, its followers are ultimately united by the shared reverence and belief in *Brahman*. Studying religious texts (Vedas,

Upanishads, etc.), festivals, dances, ceremonial rites, paying homage to different deities, following specific diet rituals; these are all forms of ritual/ceremonial/reverential activity through which the Sacred is manifested and accessed. In Hinduism “all dance is divine,” many being “explicitly devotional in tone”(Narayanan, 350). The rituals within Hinduism are especially important, because while many Hindus may not be particularly acquainted with the philosophies of their religion, they still “observe the practices all their lives”(Narayanan, 337). Hinduism also emphasizes one’s individual path, *marga*, which is developed through discipline, *yoga*, the accumulation of *karma*, wisdom, *jnana*, and devotional practice, *bhakti* (2025.03.24, 21). Bhakti yoga is “self-abnegation” via which the worshipper “seeks union with the Supreme being through passionate devotion”(Narayanan, 328). We can see that the spiritual elements of Hinduism hinge on individuals’ own relationship with, devotion to, and discipline in becoming one with the divine; the *atman* (self) becoming one with *Brahman* (the universe, ultimate reality); individual religious experience. Yoga is also a system of moral discipline; karma yoga (Narayanan, 327). Karma is essentially the “rewards & punishments attached to various actions... a system of cause and effect” (Narayanan, 311), and this truth in Hinduism governs individuals’ behavior, their sense of morality, as well as society’s. Hindu society is stratified, laid out by the caste system, “shorthand for the thousand of social and occupational division” that date back thousands of years to one of the Vedic creation hymns. Social order has been kept and reflected in the *Laws of Manu*, that illustrate “righteousness, moral duty, and law”(Narayanan, 323); morality and the functioning of society is constructed from ancient Hindu religious scriptures and concepts.

Now onto Islam, one of the three Abrahamic religions. “Islam” is defined as “submission,” reflecting “Muslim belief in the importance of submitting to God’s will”(Brodd, 481), with the “most important principle of Islamic belief is the oneness of God”(Brodd, 486). God, or Allah, is clearly held Sacred to Muslims; the belief in and submission to Allah (the Sacred for Islam) serves as the most crucial, foundational focal point for Islamic worship and practice. To associate anything else with Allah, *shirk*, is “the only unforgivable sin in the eyes of Allah”(Brodd, 486) because it directly rejects what is the most Sacred in Islam; religion is formulated upon the belief in some form of Sacred. The structure of Islam and

the doctrine that defines its religious worldview comes from the Qur'an, the "primary source of Islamic teachings"(Brodd, 482), and seen through the Five Pillars, which are clear-cut requirements for practitioners of the religion that form the basis of practice. The doctrine of Islam in essence is the belief in Allah; the "most important principle of Islamic belief is the oneness of God"(Brodd, 486), this being the core of Islam's structure and "what exists, what can be known, what should be valued, how one should behave, and what the immediate and ultimate goals of life ought to be". Four of out of five of the pillars in Islam are rituals/reverential activities expected of and performed by Muslims, some daily like *Salat*, some yearly like *Sawm*, and some at least once in a lifetime, the *Hajj*. To be a Muslim, especially to be considered a devout one, necessitates consistent performance of these expected rituals and highlights the role ritual plays in defining religion. The clarification of sin and condemnation of it demonstrates how religion is partly defined by how it guides morality and social order, and for Islam the Qur'an's verses serve as "guidelines for moral behavior"(Brodd, 485), and to reject the faith means "failing to live up to prescribed duties and moral standards"(Brodd, 487). Islamic societies are furthermore governed by *Sharia*, Islamic law, which "regulates almost every aspect of daily life for believers"(Brodd, 522). As for individual religious experience, the daily prayers along with the lifelong submission to Allah imbue meaning, structure, and purpose in Muslims' lives and practices; the highly devotional nature of Islam inherently denotes personal religious experience as an integral part of their livelihood. We can also examine Sufism, a mystical branch of Islam that pays special importance to strengthening one's personal relationship and experiences with Allah (Brodd, 523), its meditative practices arranged for "mystical union with the divine"(2025.03.02, 17). In William James' *The Varieties of Religious Experience* where he discusses mysticism, he points out Sufism as an example of "achieving mystic states; surpassing the wall between individual and Absolute; oneness"(James, 350).

We've now discussed three examples of religions that fit into my definition, so let's explore some of the more nuanced cases where certain components may be omitted. In David Brooks' personal essay, "The Shock of Fatih," he details his experience of rediscovering faith through Christianity while continuing to identify as Jewish. In his background, he claims that during the time period where he was

agnostic, he was “religious but not spiritual,” growing up in a “Jewish home where [he] experienced *peoplehood* more than *faith*.” He thus implies that what distinguishes religion from spirituality is “peoplehood,” or in other terms the community and organized structure inherent in religion; this, not “faith,” or stern conviction in some form of Sacred, higher power is what delineates religion. One can never have experienced the latter but still be considered religious because of their membership within the specific communal/organized spheres religion provides. Additionally, in Soliman’s article on embodied cognition he notes: “There are many *non-believing* Jewish individuals who cherish their genetic heritage more than their beliefs (indeed, Judaism has been characterized as a *religion of descent* rather than assent” (Soliman, 857). Combining Brooks’ own claims with Soliman’s observation on Judaism, religion does not have to include belief in a Sacred; its followers unobliged to follow any set of doctrines or expected rituals; it can instead be defined by the cultural, biological heritage shared by followers. This is somewhat the case for Hinduism as well, as we’ve talked about earlier about the term’s origins stemming from Hindus shared geographical and cultural ancestry. In relation to my assertion that religion works to instill morality in its followers, Brooks remarks that “over the past decade, especially in the American church, [he’s] seen religious people behaving more viciously, more dishonestly, and, in some ways, being more tolerant of sexual abuse” (Brooks, 9). What I’m taking away from this is that religion is an institution of power; rather than guiding moral behavior, it’s a system where individuals can create and leverage their platforms for influence, but not necessarily for the betterment of society; it can be used to attack, manipulate, and ostracize. This is a side of religion not only unique to the U.S, to the Christian church, but in any domain where religion holds influence. One example is in India, where acts of violence against Muslims have tended to increase before elections that political scientists attribute to Hindu parties’ efforts to galvanize their base (Shih & Ifran, 2-3). Therefore, religion doesn’t have to be defined by a source of moral guidance or faith in a sacred power. It can be defined as an organization where membership is given based on genetic, cultural, or geographic similarities, or as a system of power that categorizes groups of people, creating an “us” and a “them;” a system of *othering*: “‘Religion’ is what people encounter when they discover that other people don’t think, feel, believe, or worship as they do” (2025.04.28, 2).

This essay is an exhibition of my efforts to define religion, after an entire semester of learning about the various facets, approaches to, varieties, and implications of religion. I'll be leaving this class with deeper insights into the ontology of religion, the numerous ways it manifests in our world, and the impacts it has on us individually and societally that often occur unseen, unannounced. During the process of writing this essay, I struggled to come up with five components to define religion while trying to keep in mind all the diverse arguments introduced in class every week. Now that I'm nearing the end, I've come to appreciate all the nuance and complexity religious scholars face whenever having to make any sort of claim about religion. Researching, writing, and debating with my own self the nature of religion has been a stimulating exercise that's led me to this conclusion; all definitions of religion contain validity to a significant extent. It all depends on the context of the work being done such as the cultural circumstances, the scholars' objectives, and the purposes different definitions may serve within a broader academic or political environment. I'm leaving with the belief – supported by the knowledge I've acquired from this course and my personal journey writing this piece – that religion is not a black and white term but a concept that has, arguably, somewhat been solidified by much historical precedence, yet nevertheless is open to new revelations, discoveries, and modifications.